

Complete Guide on Secondary Research

Objective: Researching on Building Green/Sustainable Campuses

Step 1

What exactly to do?

Understand the Macro Environment and the industry (What exactly is green campus, read research on green/sustainable campuses by universities and consulting firms, regulations and policy, overall sustainability trends)

Sources

1. Articles
2. Research reports by consulting firms and universities

Example:

Talks about integrating sustainability into education and implementing eco-friendly campus operations. Challenges in green campuses and recommendations for the same. Talks about very specific initiatives as well.

<https://www.frontiersin.org/journals/sustainable-cities/articles/10.3389/frsc.2025.1469274/full?>

Talks about roles of higher education institutions in promoting sustainability – role of different stakeholders and how to propagate sustainability goals in campuses

<https://www2.deloitte.com/content/dam/Deloitte/us/Documents/public-sector/advancing-sustainability-in-higher-education-holistic-approach-for-colleges-universities.pdf>

https://www.appa.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/03/Pages-from-GreenCampus_Excerptv2.pdf?

Try to collect data points/ graphs & numbers in the first step from consulting reports – wherever possible

<https://www.ey.com/content/dam/ey-unified-site/ey-com/en-us/insights/education/documents/ey-esg-in-higher-education-from-strategy-to-execution.pdf>

Figure 3: Importance of environmental sustainability

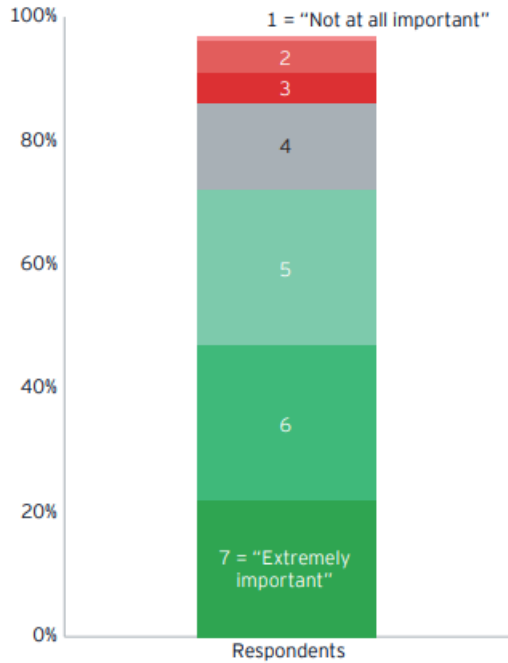
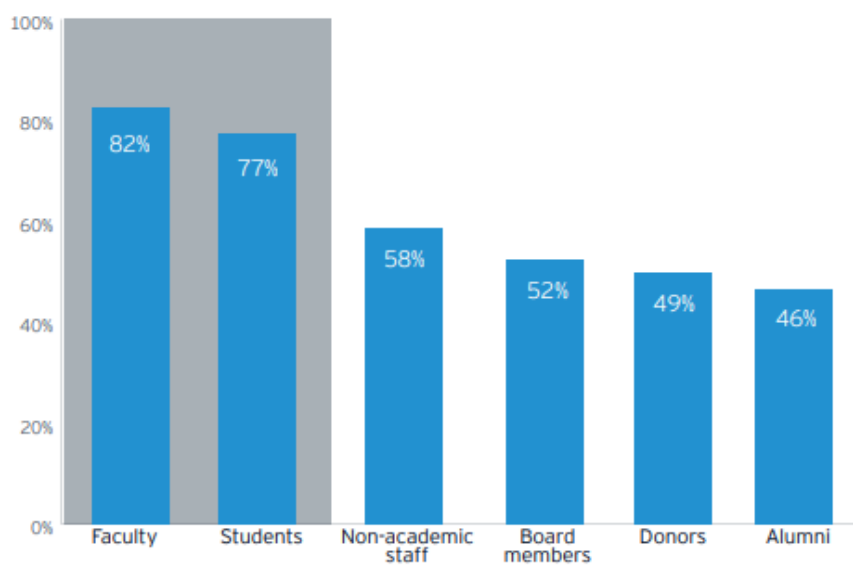
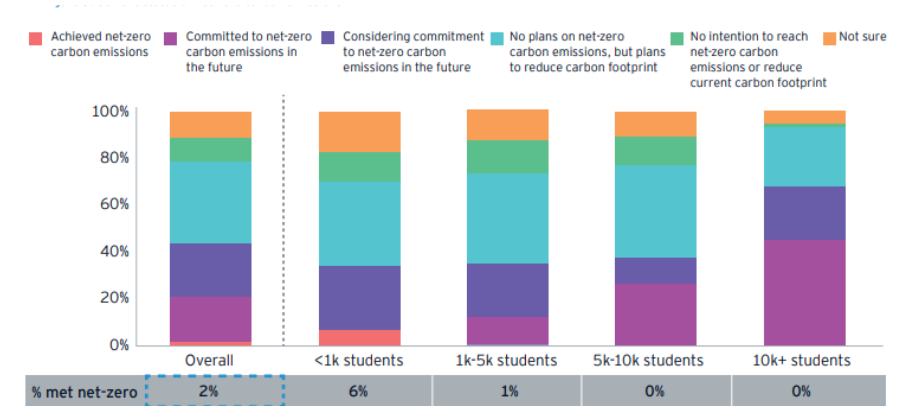
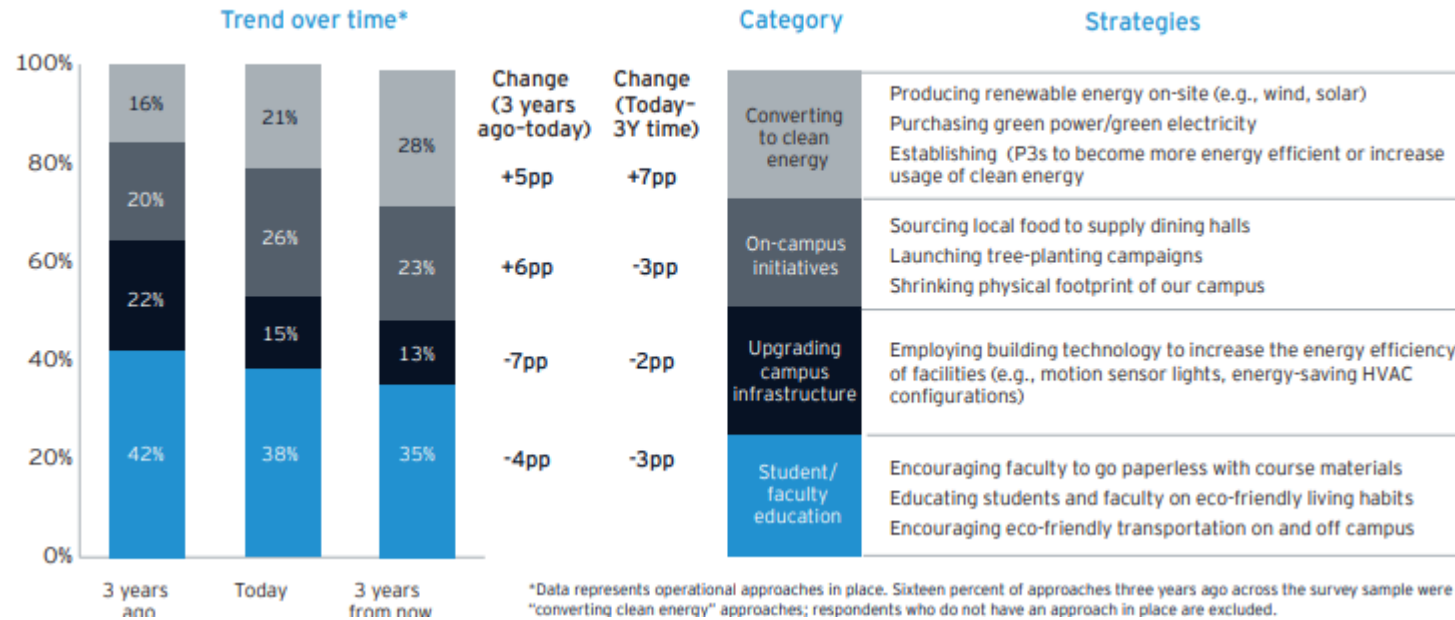


Figure 4: Importance of institutional commitment to environmental sustainability, by stakeholder group



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Figure 10. Institutional strategies to reduce carbon emissions



Tips:

1. Consulting reports by Deloitte, EY, KPMG, Accenture, McKinsey, BCG, Bain may often result in great data points on the industry or the specific topic (Keyword: Green campuses Deloitte)
2. If not exactly on Green Campus, you can read reports on overall sustainability practices which will give a starting point. Similarly for credit card research, you may read reports on overall digital payment landscape for macro insights

Hint: Paste the report link in ChatGPT and ask it to summarize it. Read only the relevant reports!

If it is a regulated industry or has several policies, I will also try to look for any policy and relation announcements in the industry along with the industry trends - PESTEL

<https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/city/indore/davv-affiliation-norms-changed-colleges-must-ensure-30-green-cover-in-3-years/articleshow/121195347.cms?>

<https://www.aicte-india.org/Initiatives/clean-green-campus?>

Insights from Step 1:

Overview on Green Campus and sustainability efforts (*Overview of the industry*)

Policies/regulation related to Green Campus

Technological and social trends and innovations towards green campus and sustainability in general

Need and requirements to shift to a Green Campus (*Need and requirements of the product/service*)

Step 2

What exactly to do?

Company or Brand Specific Research

Sources

1. Company Website
2. Company Annual Reports

Here we are not looking at a specific university, hence we won't deep dive but if the university name is mentioned we would have deep dived into:

1. Overall vision and mission of the university
2. Current USPs and SWOT of the campus/university
3. Sustainability Initiatives taken by the university (Quantifiable metrics too that can be compared with other universities)
4. Future Plans (Business related and sustainability related)
5. Overall Financials (if I require it later to understand the feasibility of recommendations)

Step 3

What exactly to do?

Competitor and Substitutes Research.

Collect global and local case studies on the product/service/initiative

Sources

1. Google search on similar ideas and case studies
2. Competitor websites

In this case,

Competitors: Other Educational Institutions (Global and local)

Substitute: Other Green Infrastructure projects (can be residential projects, office buildings etc.)

For example, Global case studies

<https://www.aucegypt.edu/news/stories/aucs-green-campus-global-exemplar-sustainability-un-universities-toolkit?>

<https://ucc.edu.gh/news/ucc-records-over-90-success-its-green-campus-project?>

<https://www.ecocampus.global/stories?>

Indian Case Studies

https://sc-evcapi.aicte-india.org/files/essential_document/File_essential_22698_17823_6c0cc159-5ed0-4bec-a621-15e1c5dcd38f.pdf?

<https://elion.co.in/transforming-campus-sustainability-a-pune-college-case-study/?>

Substitute Case Studies (Green initiatives by malls, residential units and other infrastructure)

<https://nzeb.in/case-studies/nzebs-in-india/nzebs-in-india-case-studies-list/ipb-case-study/?>

<https://www.sintali.com/case-study-phoenix-citadel-india?>

<https://www.washingtonpost.com/climate-solutions/2025/03/25/palava-city-net-zero-india/?>

Insights from Step 3:

1. Global and Local Case Studies and best practices
2. Key lessons from case studies that can be considered for implementation
3. Impact metrics, awards, recognitions and benefits
4. Funding sources, investments and business models (track revenue streams in case of a product/service)

Based on all these, we can map our competitor/substitute benchmarking as well with some of the key factors being

Project Name

Initiatives undertaken

Impact created

Benefits (Qualitative and Quantitative, if possible)

Challenges/Failures (if any)

Investment Required

Funding mechanism

Awards & Recognition

(We can choose any 4-5 factors and make a good Competitor or Substitute benchmarking for key insights)

Step 4

What exactly to do?

Industry Metrics and Quantifiable Data (if possible)

Market size, growth, company market share, investments in the industry, future outlook, comparable financials

Sources

1. Statista
2. Markets & Data Website
3. CRISIL
4. DRHP Reports by companies
5. Annual Reports of any company in the specific industry

Here we look at the quantifiable metrics or data points. For a product/service we would look at Market Size, TAM, SAM, SOM, Industry Growth, Market Share, Company Financials vs Competitors, associated indirect metrics (Like boom in e-commerce purchase if we are strategizing for credit cards), and even do guesstimates to predict possible revenue for the business

For Green Campuses, we will look at investments, financing options that have driven past projects, government subsidies (if any), potential savings by competitors/substitutes (Remember this can be any sustainable initiatives to improve the infrastructure and not necessarily Educational Institutions)

Overall Market Trends

<https://www.marketsanddata.com/industry-reports/india-green-building-market?>

<https://www.ceew.in/press-releases/indian-municipal-green-bonds-market-could-mobilise-to-usd-2.5-billion-and-boost-climate-resilient-urban-growth?>

<https://economictimes.indiatimes.com/news/economy/infrastructure/green-investments-in-india-to-rise-5x-to-rs-31-lakh-cr-through-2030-crisil/articleshow/117268927.cms?>

Sustainable Finance Market

<https://www.globenewswire.com/news-release/2025/05/01/3072129/28124/en/Sustainable-Finance-Market-Research-and-Growth-Forecast-2025-2034-BNP-Paribas-BlackRock-UBS-Bank-of-America-and-HSBC-Group-Dominate.html>

Benefits and examples of impact metrics

Savings achieved in terms of energy, water and utilities

<https://www.sintali.com/case-study-phoenix-citadel-india>

“total harvestable water was calculated to be **64,635.432 m³** from the roofs (floor area) in the campus area of Erciyes University. Accordingly, it is possible to save approximately **7.55%** of the annual water consumption, **saving 1,066,477 TL** and supplying water to 7,181 people per year by harvesting rainwater from the roofs at Erciyes University”

<https://www.researchgate.net/publication/380268988> Research Rainwater Harvesting Potential of Erciyes University Campus Based on The UI GreenMetric Ranking

“University of New Orleans has a brand-new solar array that officials say will offset **17% of** the school's annual electrical consumption. UNO estimates it will save **\$2.1 million annually** with the solar array and other energy efficiencies”

<https://www.axios.com/local/new-orleans/2024/04/08/university-new-orleans-solar-array>

Waste Diversion Report

<https://www.rochester.edu/sustainability/wp-content/uploads/2025/05/2024-Year-end-Recycling-Waste-Report-v3.pdf>

Biodiversity

https://www.itreetools.org/documents/352/UPenn_iTreeEcoInventory.pdf

https://facilityservices.ucsd.edu/_files/WhyWePlantTrees-9.20.22.pdf

Insights from Step 4:

1. Market trends, investments, funding sources and value
2. Benefits and possible quantitative impact (from real life case studies or potential opportunities)
3. Financials and key numbers of competitors and substitutes
4. KPIs and Impact Metrics to track
5. In case of products and services – Market size, growth, consumer trends, cost estimation and revenue estimation can be important

Tip: DRHP reports are great to analyze an industry in detail. Companies file it before their IPO. Read SBI Cards DRHP report – that will give a detailed insight on credit card industry!

Step 5

What exactly to do?

Deep dive further into relevant insights for your recommendation

Deep dive into any specific recommendation/initiatives, revenue stream, business model, consumer insight to explore and find other examples or data points

Sources

1. Statista
2. Government Websites or official databases
3. Specific case study articles/LinkedIn Posts

For example, here we know waste removal, water harvesting, alternative sources of energy are some common themes observed. We can find more on how to do it and collect practical implementable documents from other sources

Also green bonds, subsidies etc. are financing instruments we found – we can think about consolidating the bodies responsible for these and research on them and any specific conditions/certifications they require

This can be merged with primary research and consumer/stakeholder Insights to make your recommendations and solutions. Remember if you have amazing secondary research data points – primary research may not even be required!

Example, this is a roadmap of a specific campus which can itself be used to outline your strategy and make recommendations

<https://www.redcampussustainable.cl/wp-content/uploads/2022/07/1-Blueprint-For-Green-Campus.pdf>

Another example of a website which has outlined campus sustainability strategy in detail

<https://sustainability.nus.edu.sg/campus-sustainability/>

Insights from Step 5:

1. Practical, implementable strategies for the recommendation
2. Challenges/Risks in the implementation or risks of not undertaking these initiatives which can be listed on introductory slides to escalate the need of these initiatives
3. Key Themes to focus on and ideal practices to take forward
4. Bridging the gaps in the business model (if you want to build a business model canvas, it can be done at this stage)

Step 6 (Optional)

What exactly to do?

Any specific Analysis

Building user personas, perceptual maps, sentiment analysis

Sources

1. Review/Rating sites
2. Kantar (Survey)
3. Consulting Consumer Insights report
4. NielsenIQ (For FMCG)

Everything we did with primary research – user personas, perceptual maps and sentiment analysis – can be done through secondary research

For example, for a product/service - go to their website/store and track the reviews for sentiment analysis and understanding the type of user (what language do they write in, male/female, estimated age etc.)

At the same time, what is their message in advertising and what messages do their competitors give? Use this for 2x2 perceptual maps.

If you are not able to collect enough responses in a survey, talk to few key stakeholders that will give you primary insights & a direction. Then corroborate that with your secondary research!